

Peer Review – Student Guidelines

Trimester 2 2026 | Read this document before completing your first peer review form

These guidelines explain how peer review works in this course: how it is conducted, how feedback is shared, and how it may affect your individual mark. Examples are included to clarify expectations.

Peer review is conducted twice during the trimester, once for each assignment:

- Milestone 1 Peer Review (Week 5) – linked to the Milestone 1 submission
- Final Submission Peer Review (Week 10) – linked to the Final Submission

This is a transparent peer review process: both written feedback and ratings are shared with teammates before the submission deadline.

Contents

1. What is Peer Review and Why it is Used
2. How the Process Works
3. Rating Scale and Evidence
4. How Mark Adjustments Work
5. Sharing Feedback with Your Team
6. Responsibilities
7. Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is Peer Review and Why it is Used

Group assignments are marked as a team, so every member starts with the same group mark. In practice, individual contributions are rarely equal. Peer review gives the teaching team evidence of each student's actual contribution, so individual marks can be adjusted where it is fair to do so.

Why this process exists:

1. It creates a record of what each teammate actually contributed, so contribution is not just guessed.
2. Feedback shared after Milestone 1 gives you a real opportunity to improve before the Final Submission — the gap between the two rounds is a genuine window for improvement, not a formality.
3. It gives the teaching team evidence to decide whether an individual mark adjustment is fair.

Note

Your group mark is the starting point for every team member.

If your contribution is in line with what is expected of a team member, your mark stays the same as the group mark. If your rating falls below what is expected, your individual mark may be reduced using the table in Section 4.

Peer review can only reduce a mark — it can never increase your mark above the group mark.

2. How the Process Works

Each round follows the same four stages: Complete → Share → Reflect → Submit.

Stage	Milestone 1	Final Submission	What to do
Complete	By end of Week 4	By end of Week 9	Complete Section 1 (Self-Review) once, and Section 2 (Peer Review) for each teammate. Do not complete Section 3 yet.
Share	By end of Week 4	By end of Week 9	Privately share your written feedback and rating with each teammate (Teams, WhatsApp, Discord, or email) — never in the group chat.
Reflect	Weeks 4–5	Weeks 9–10	Read the feedback you receive, keep attending team meetings, then complete Section 3 (Self-Reflection).
Submit	By end of Week 5	By end of Week 10	Submit Sections 1–3 via the peer review submission link. The Team Leader also submits Section 4 (Peer Rating Summary).

Submission summary

- Every team member submits Sections 1, 2 and 3 individually.
- The Team Leader additionally submits Section 4 (Peer Rating Summary) for that round.
- Milestone 1 ratings affect only the Milestone 1 mark. Final Submission ratings affect only the Final Submission mark. The two rounds are independent and are never combined or averaged.

What the form asks you to do

Section	Purpose
---------	---------

Section	Purpose
1: Self-Review	Reflect on your own role: tasks completed, challenges faced, one area to improve, and a rating of your own contribution (1–5, justified with evidence).
2: Peer Review	One copy per teammate: their role and contributions, your assessment of their professionalism and teamwork, one constructive suggestion, and a rating (1–5, justified with evidence).
3: Self-Reflection	Completed only after reading the Section 2 feedback from your teammates: what you learned, whether the feedback felt fair, what you will do differently, and how the team is functioning as a whole.
4: Peer Rating Summary (Team Leader only)	Collect and record every teammate's ratings into the summary table for that round.

3. Rating Scale and Evidence

Every rating — in your Self-Review and in each Peer Review — uses the same 1–5 scale. Your written response must justify the rating you give: a rating with no supporting evidence will be queried by the teaching team, and this applies equally to the rating you give yourself.

Rating	Meaning	Example evidence
5	Better than expected	Went beyond the assigned tasks, proactively supported struggling teammates, delivered ahead of schedule, took the initiative to fix a critical problem.
4	As expected	Completed assigned tasks on time, attended and contributed to meetings, communicated proactively, met the standard expected of a team member.
3	Slightly less than expected	Late to a few regular meetings, a few days' delay delivering an artefact, occasionally slow to respond to messages, needed one or two reminders.
2	Significantly less than expected	Frequently missed meetings or deadlines without notice, delivered work that required substantial rework by others, needed repeated follow-up to complete basic tasks.
1	No contribution at all	Did not attend any meetings, submitted no work, unreachable or unresponsive throughout the period, contribution entirely carried by other members.

What counts as evidence

- Code committed to the shared repository — features, bug fixes, pull requests.
- Report sections, diagrams, or README content drafted or completed.
- Test cases written, code reviewed, or bugs found and reported.
- Active participation in team meetings — contributing to decisions, not just attending.

- Responding to messages, flagging blockers, keeping the group informed when something is delayed.
- Taking ownership of a task and seeing it through to completion without needing to be followed up.

Score and written response must match

A rating of 2 paired with the comment “great team member, always helpful” will be queried, and so will a rating of 5 with no specific evidence of what that person actually did. If you give someone (or yourself) a low rating, your written response must describe specifically what you observed that supports it.

Example — vague vs. specific feedback

Too vague: “Good team member. Always helpful.” — tells the person nothing they can act on, and cannot be verified by the teaching team.

Better: “You took the lead on the database schema in Week 3 and explained your design choices clearly, which saved the group time during integration.” — names a task, a timeframe, and its impact.

4. How Mark Adjustments Work

Each round is assessed independently. Milestone 1 ratings can only adjust the Milestone 1 mark; Final Submission ratings can only adjust the Final Submission mark. Any adjustment applies to your group mark for that assignment only — never to your overall course grade, and never above the group mark.

Your score for a round is the average of the individual ratings your teammates gave you (out of 5). This average is compared directly against the fixed thresholds below to determine any adjustment. It is not compared against your teammates' scores.

Average Peer Rating	Adjustment	What this means
≥ 3.5	No adjustment	Your contribution met or exceeded expectations.
2.5 – 3.49	–10%	Your contribution was slightly below expectations.
1.5 – 2.49	–25%	Your contribution was significantly below expectations.
> 1 – 1.49	–50%	Your contribution was very limited.
= 1	0 marks for that assignment	You made no contribution at all.

How the deduction is calculated: the percentage is deducted from your group mark for that assignment. For example, a group mark of 68% with a –10% adjustment loses 10% of 68 = 6.8 marks, giving a final mark of 61.2% (rounded to 61%).

Example — one round, one team

The group mark for this assignment is 68%. Each row shows a different student's outcome, illustrating every band in the table above.

Student	Avg. Peer Rating (/5)	Group Mark	Adjustment	Final Mark
Anika	4.7	68%	No adjustment (≥ 3.5)	68%

Student	Avg. Peer Rating (/5)	Group Mark	Adjustment	Final Mark
Ben	3.5	68%	No adjustment (≥ 3.5)	68%
Carla	2.6	68%	-10% (2.5–3.49)	61%
Dhruv	1.6	68%	-25% (1.5–2.49)	51%
Ellie	1.2	68%	-50% (>1 –1.49)	34%
Frank	1.0	68%	0 marks (=1)	0%

Each student's adjustment depends only on their own average rating — it is not affected by how the rest of the team was rated.

Serious outcomes are reviewed

A rating of 1 (0 marks) or in the >1 –1.49 band (–50%) is a serious outcome. Before either is finalised, the Course Convenor reviews the written peer feedback for that round. This is not automatic — the decision is based on the evidence submitted, and the student may be asked for their perspective. This review does not change the calculation; it confirms it is fair to apply.

You must justify your rating

Whatever rating you give — to yourself in Section 1, or to a teammate in Section 2 — your written response must justify it with specific evidence. Unsupported ratings may be queried or disregarded when calculating adjustments.

Penalty for not submitting your own peer review

Submitting the peer review form is a required task in its own right, separate from the ratings you receive from teammates. If you do not submit your own peer review report for a round, 5 points will be deducted from your mark for the corresponding assignment (Milestone 1 or Final Submission) — in addition to any adjustment resulting from the ratings you received.

5. Sharing Feedback with Your Team

After completing Section 2, share your written feedback and rating with each teammate individually and privately — using Teams, WhatsApp, Discord, or email. Never share in the group chat, and never just attach the form file; paste your responses directly into the message.

Share by the end of Week 4 (Milestone 1) or Week 9 (Final Submission), so your teammate has time to read it and complete Section 3 before submitting. Sharing at the last minute defeats the purpose of this window.

The teaching team only sees the aggregated summary — average scores and adjustment outcomes. You only see the ratings and feedback given to you, not what others gave.

Team discussion

After everyone has shared their feedback privately, hold a short (around 20-minute) team meeting to discuss it together. Each person shares one thing they appreciated and one honest area for improvement about a teammate,

then the team agrees on one or two specific changes for the next round. Keep the discussion constructive: the goal is to understand each other's perspective and agree on next steps, not to negotiate the numbers.

Example — raising a concern constructively

Constructive: "I found it difficult when messages went unanswered close to the deadline — would it help to agree on a response-time norm for next time?"

Not helpful: "You did less than everyone else this round." — a comparison with no specifics that puts the person on the defensive without giving them anything to act on.

If feedback you received feels unfair

Read it more than once before reacting — feedback that feels harsh at first can be more useful on reflection. If you still think a score or comment is inaccurate, raise it calmly with the person during the team discussion, referring to what they wrote. If it is not resolved, speak to your lab teacher or Course Convenor. The Self-Reflection section of your Final Submission peer review is the formal place to record how you responded to feedback, including any disagreement.

6. Responsibilities

Every team member

4. Complete and submit the peer review form individually by the deadline for each round. Not submitting results in a 5-point deduction from the corresponding assignment mark.
5. Share your Section 2 feedback and ratings privately with each teammate before the sharing deadline.
6. Read the feedback you receive and engage constructively in the team discussion.
7. Make sure every rating you give — including your own — is backed by specific written evidence.
8. Complete Section 3 in both rounds. It is mandatory, not optional.

Team Leader (in addition)

Collects every completed peer review form and enters each teammate's ratings into the Section 4 Peer Rating Summary Table for that round (one table per round). Self-ratings (marked N/A) are not entered. All entries must match the ratings given in the individual forms.

7. Frequently Asked Questions

Why do I need to submit the peer review form?

It is a required part of the group assessment. It documents your contribution, gives feedback to your teammates, and provides the evidence the teaching team uses to decide whether an individual mark adjustment applies, using the table in Section 4.

Why do I share my feedback before the submission deadline?

So your teammate has time to read it and complete their Section 3 reflection before they submit. Sharing at the last minute defeats the purpose.

What happens if a teammate does not complete their peer review?

Their rating is simply left out of your average, which is calculated from whatever ratings were submitted. The non-submitting student's own mark will be deducted by 5 points.

Do I share my numerical rating with my teammates?

Yes — this is a transparent process. You share both your written comments and the rating you gave, privately with each person, before the submission deadline.

Does my adjustment depend on what rating my teammates receive?

No. Your adjustment is based only on your own average rating against the fixed thresholds in Section 4, not on comparison with your teammates. Even if every member of your team receives a high rating, each person's adjustment is calculated independently.

Can a high rating increase my mark above the group mark?

No. The group mark is the maximum. Peer review can only reduce an individual's mark, never increase it.

Does Milestone 1 affect my Final Submission mark, or the other way around?

No. Each round only affects its own linked assignment. The two rounds are assessed independently and are never combined.

What happens if I miss the peer review submission?

You are expected to meet both the sharing deadline and the submission deadline for each round. If you do not submit your own peer review report for a round, 5 points will be deducted from your mark for the corresponding assignment, in addition to any adjustment from the ratings you received. Contact your lab teacher as early as possible if exceptional circumstances prevent you from meeting a deadline.

What does it mean if my rating triggers a –50% deduction or 0 marks?

Before either outcome is applied, the Course Convenor reviews the written feedback for that round and may ask for your perspective. Any resulting deduction only applies to the assignment linked to that round.

Can the Team Leader receive a mark adjustment?

Yes. The Team Leader is rated by their peers the same as everyone else. Being Team Leader is itself a contribution that peers can assess.

What if I completed work that my teammates did not see?

Describe it clearly in your Section 1 Self-Review, and keep your team informed of your work as you go (shared documents, commits, messages) so it is visible when peer review happens.

What if our team has only two or three members?

The process is the same, but each rating carries more weight in a smaller team. Make sure your ratings are fair and evidence-based.

Can I see how my mark adjustment was calculated?

Yes. You receive your teammates' written feedback and ratings, and the table in Section 4 shows exactly how adjustments are calculated. Contact your lab teacher with any questions.